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I'm Fine.
(I'm not.)

The anxiety reset for the woman who holds
it together for everyone else.

START HERE

You look fine. Inside, you're white-knuckling it.

You answer the emails, pack the lunches, smile in the meeting — then lie awake at 2 a.m. with your heart pounding and your mind racing through everything that could go wrong.

That's high-functioning anxiety. It's invisible precisely because you're so good at holding it together. But "managing it" is not the same as being okay.

WHAT THIS IS

Not "just relax." Real, fast tools to drop the spike in 90 seconds, untangle the spinning thoughts, and finally quiet the 2 a.m. spiral.

STEP 1

Name it: the body check

Anxiety lives in the body before it reaches your thoughts. Naming where you feel it actually turns the volume down. Circle yours:

- ☐ Tight chest / hard to take a full breath
- ☐ Racing or pounding heart
- ☐ Clenched jaw, shoulders up by your ears
- ☐ Knot or churn in your stomach
- ☐ Restless, can't sit still / can't focus
- ☐ Buzzing dread with no clear cause

Right now, I feel it most in my:

"I notice my chest is tight." That sentence alone tells your brain you're observing, not in danger. The spike starts to ease.

STEP 2

The 90-second reset

When the wave hits, do this. It works *with* your nervous system, not against it.

- 1 Double inhale, long exhale.** Two quick breaths in through the nose, one slow breath out through the mouth. Repeat 4×. (This is the fastest known way to calm the body.)

- 2 5-4-3-2-1.** Name 5 things you see, 4 you can touch, 3 you hear, 2 you smell, 1 you taste. Pulls you out of your head, into the room.

- 3 Feet on the floor.** Press them down. Say: "I am here. I am safe right now." Right now is almost always okay.

STEP 3

The worry sort

Anxiety treats every worry as urgent and true. Dump them out, then drop each into one box. Most won't survive the sort.

I can act on it

There's one small step. Write it — that's tomorrow's job, not tonight's.

I can't control it

Not mine to carry. Name it and set it down.

Not even likely

The "what if" that fear invented. Thank it, release it.

A worry you can't act on, can't control, and that probably won't happen is not a task. It's just a feeling wearing a costume.

STEP 4

The 2 a.m. wind-down

For the nights the spiral wakes you. Don't fight it — route it:

- **Brain dump.** Everything looping, onto paper by the bed. Out of your head, onto the page.
- **One tomorrow-action.** Pick the single most useful thing and write it down. The rest can wait.
- **Slow body scan.** From your toes up, soften each part. Pair with the long exhale from Step 2.
- **Permission.** "Nothing gets solved at 2 a.m. My only job right now is to rest."

Tomorrow's one thing:

You're allowed to not be fine.

Read them. Mean them.

- I don't have to earn rest by worrying first.
- A calm body is a skill, not a personality I lack.
- I can ask for help without it meaning I failed.
- Most of what I fear will never happen.
- "Fine" is not the goal. Honest and steady is.

One kind thing I'll do for my nervous system today:

A self-help tool, not therapy. If anxiety is overwhelming or constant, please reach out to a mental-health professional.

You don't have to hold it all. Just breathe.

Two breaths in, one long breath out. Sort the worry. Put down what was never yours to carry. You are allowed to be a person, not a machine.

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